

1649–1660

PURITAN INFLUENCE

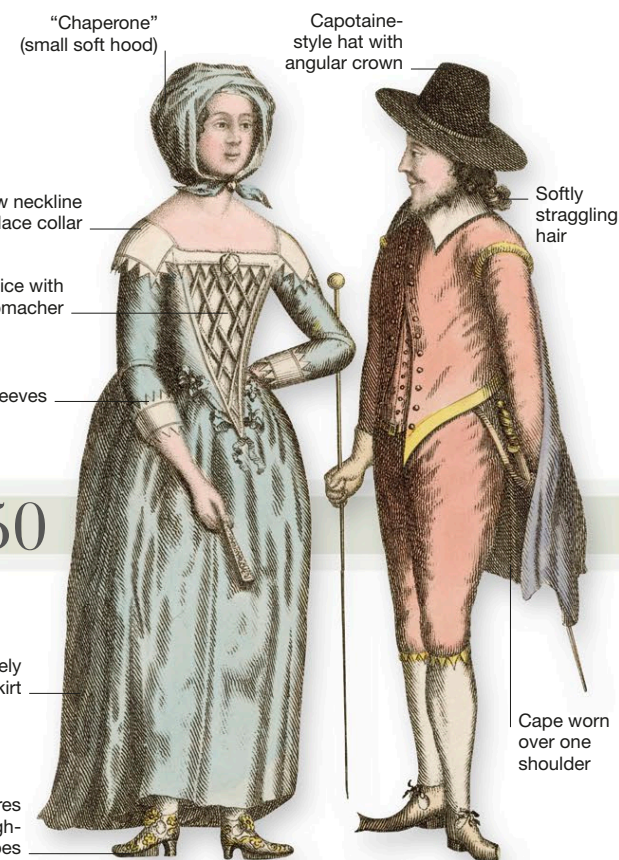
After King Charles I was executed in 1649, England became a republic called the Commonwealth, with Oliver Cromwell at its head. Cromwell, a Protestant and a Puritan, believed that people should lead pious lives and dress in a plain and practical way. His opponents, the Royalists, supported a return to the monarchy and wore elaborate clothing inspired by French fashion. Cromwell's Puritans based their dress on Dutch traditions, since the Dutch United Provinces (now the Netherlands) was a strongly Protestant country as well as a wealthy, influential one. Many style features associated with this period – such as linen collars covering the shoulders and the widespread popularity of black – are Dutch in origin. Dark clothes with little or no decoration were favoured. English Puritans, a branch of Protestants, established a colony in Plymouth, Massachusetts, in what is now the US, in 1620 that would influence all aspects of American culture, including fashion.



1654



1655



1650

Into the Commonwealth At the beginning of this period in England, people were still wearing fashions from Charles I's time. The laced stomacher (front panel) of the lady's bodice and soft-toned colour of the man's doublet were both styles from the 1640s.



1657

Dutch servant In a detail from a painting by Jacobus Vrel, this young servant girl wears clothes of linen and wool fabrics, with names like "serge" and "linsey wooley". These would have been far less expensive than silk and cotton.

Seated woman In this Nicolaes Maes painting, c.1655, a Dutch housewife mends a linen shirt. Linen was woven in the city of Haarlem, exported widely, and used locally for both clothing and domestic textiles.

Merchant class Artist Pieter de Hooch offers a glimpse of Dutch domestic life in the 17th century. The prosperous couple is dressed in black, but with luxurious details, such as the woman's silver petticoat and laced bodice.